Writing a Short Response Guide

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Approaching different assessment tasks - Short responses

Short responses have become a very common assessment type at SCU. They can be formatted in different ways. Always check the assessment details and rubric to understand requirements.

It is important not to underestimate how much time these shorter assessments take to put together. Add tasks to your weekly study schedule in the same way you would for any task.

Short response assessments do share common features and structure. Understanding these common elements can make it easier to write your short response assessments, and help you to improve grades.

Low-stakes

These lower-weighted assessments give you a chance to engage with unit content and get feedback. They offer an opportunity to improve your overall grade for the unit.

Shorter word count

Use a concise style where every word counts.

PEEL paragraph structure

Strictly following the PEEL body paragraph structure to use a concise evidence-rich writing style.

Narrow focus

Offer a narrow but deep discussion that covers just **one or two** examples or issues in a bit of detail.

Direct informed response

Make sure that you use **unit content** to offer your direct answer.

Common short response assessment structure:

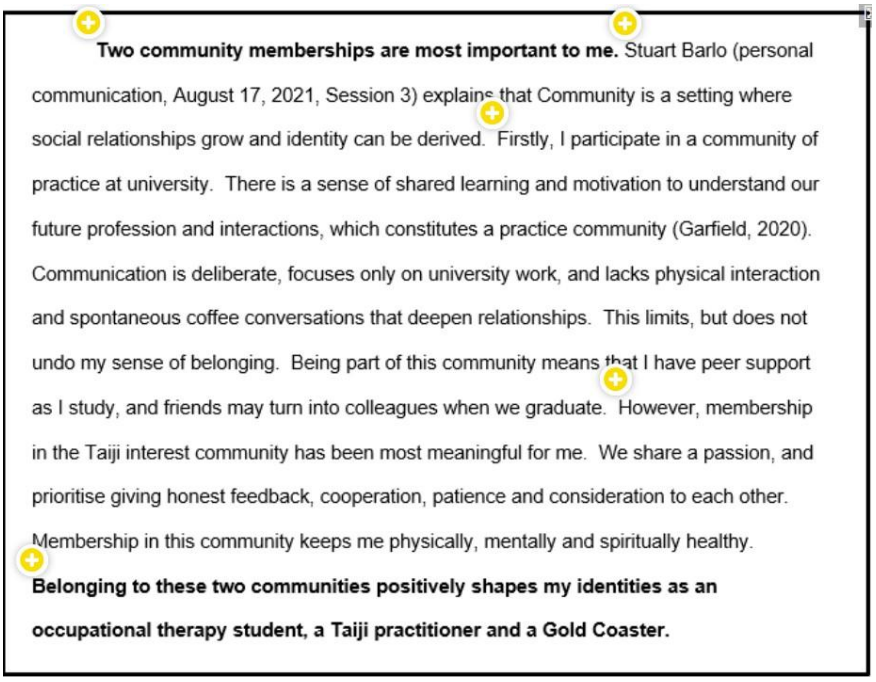
1. First, state your informed response, or direct answer to the question. Use keywords from the question.
2. The rest of the short response should **only** develop (evidence and explain) your informed answer.
3. Conclude the response by summarising your direct answer and any implications you have discussed (no new information).

Seeing an example of a short response written by an SCU student can be helpful. The example below was a short response discussion board post. The word limit was 200 words. **The question was**: what type of communities do you belong to?

Response stated

The **first sentence** states the **informed answer** using **key words** from the question.

Evidence elaborating the response - This second sentence includes a **referenced definition** of the **key concept** used in the response (community). This simple strategy is an easy way to earn marks.



Two community memberships are most important to me. Stuart Barlo (personal communication, August 17, 2021, Session 3) explains that Community is a setting where social relationships grow and identity can be derived. Firstly, I participate in a community of practice at university. There is a sense of shared learning and motivation to understand our future profession and interactions, which constitutes a practice community (Garfield, 2020). Communication is deliberate, focuses only on university work, and lacks physical interaction and spontaneous coffee conversations that deepen relationships. This limits, but does not undo my sense of belonging. Being part of this community means that I have peer support as I study, and friends may turn into colleagues when we graduate. However, membership in the Taiji interest community has been most meaningful for me. We share a passion, and prioritise giving honest feedback, cooperation, patience and consideration to each other. Membership in this community keeps me physically, mentally and spiritually healthy. **Belonging to these two communities positively shapes my identities as an occupational therapy student, a Taiji practitioner and a Gold Coaster.**

First reason (supporting point)

The next group of sentences all evidence and develop the **first reason** (or **supporting point)** offered in this short response.

Second reason (supporting point)

The next group of sentences all develop and evidence the **second reason** offered in this short response.

Response re-stated - This final sentence **re-states** the student's **direct answer** to the question in a way that **summarises implications** (without introducing new information).

TIPS

Start early

You will still need to read, research, note-make, brainstorm, plan, draft and edit your assessment. The actual writing and editing phases are likely to take around a third **of the overall time** it takes to complete the task.

This means it is important to:

- **start early** (probably earlier than you think)
- **allow enough time** for reading/research, note-making, and planning phases
- add tasks to your **weekly study schedule**.

Use unit approaches

Always use **unit approaches** (concepts, theories, models, processes or guidelines) in your short responses. Often, this means **defining and applying** unit concepts or theories**.** At higher levels of study short response assessments often ask students to **evaluate** unit theory**.** Always check assessment requirements.

Before you start working on the assessment, find definitions in unit materials. This step will help you gain a more **detailed grasp** of unit ideas and theories so that you can **show this understanding** to the marker.

Be strategic

It is easy to dismiss short response assessments as not that important because they have a low weighting compared to other assessments. However, doing well on these tasks is an **easy way to improve your grade for the unit.** Just as importantly, these shorter assessments can offer a chance to **get early feedback** from your tutor, supporting your results in later tasks.

Use a coherent structure

Make it easy for your marker to understand your position, or **response** by **structuring your assessment coherently** and **using PEEL body paragraphs**.

Structure short response assessments so that they:

- **start** by clearly **stating your direct answer** to the question (your position/main point)
- present **reasons** (supporting points) and **reliable evidence** that support and develop **your response**
- offer a logical reading path (think about the order of your discussion)
- conclude by **summarising your response** (or position), and **implications** (discussed in the assessment).

Use **PEEL struture** for **all** body paragraphs. **The first sentence** should state **the key point of the paragraph. Remaining sentences should** elaborate and develop **the same key point,** using **reliable evidence**.

A useful model for writing paragraphs is the **PEEL** method. **P** (point) represents the topic sentence or key point. The **E**‘s signify explanation, elaboration, examples, and evidence. **L** (link) denotes the concluding sentence that links to the thesis and may link to the next paragraph.

Coherent structure can help you to **save time and words** as well as **improve grades**.

Narrow, narrow, narrow your focus

Short responses are **narrow but deep** academic discussions.

Don't try to COVER EVERYTHING you know about a topic. While it can be tempting, this is **not your task** in a short response, and you don't have enough words. Your job is to offer your **informed answer** to the question within a limited word-count. It is very likely that you only offer and evidence **one or two reasons** (supporting points). Longer response papers might offer three or four supporting points.

As you brainstorm, plan and draft keep trying to **narrow, narrow, narrow your focus**. Keep asking what **can't be left out** and still meet requirements. Doing this will help you to make decisions about how to **focus your short response**.

Pretend your reader disagrees with you

Sometimes writing short responses can be difficult because **we can't "see" our position**, or main point. This can happen during the reading and planning phases, when we are experiencing **information overload.**

It can help to **pretend that your reader disagrees** with your answer/response. Make a **short list** of **reasons** and **evidence** you could use **to persuade them.** This quick excercise can make writing phase much quicker and easier. Always check your list against assessment requirements to make sure that you stay on track.